Up till then, all of the players in the team had only watched others take part in a World Cup final. Now it was our turn. The excitement back home was extraordinary and a huge number of people had come to South Africa to cheer on the team. We had peaked at the right time and were playing some really good cricket. Naturally we were all determined to give our best in the final but perhaps we got ourselves too wound up. The evening before the final the team decided to spend some time in the pool. To our surprise, the water was freezing but that did not stop us from jumping in together. I didn't sleep well that night.

When we got to the ground the next morning, we immediately went over to take a look at the surface. It was apparent to us all that there was moisture in the pitch and, given it was a day game, the fast bowlers were sure to get some early assistance. It would not be a bad idea to field first if we won the toss. That's what we did, but the decision turned out to be a disaster, with Ricky Ponting playing one of the best one-day innings of all time, making 140. Australia scored a mammoth 359 in their fifty overs and had almost batted us out of the game.

In hindsight, I would still have opted to field. It was because we could not keep a lid on our excitement that we lost the plot early on. Zaheer conceded 15 runs in the first over and though we still felt we could make a comeback after that one bad over, it just didn't happen. Towards the concluding stages of their innings, every big shot that Ponting played made our task that much more difficult. In a final, every run scored after the total passes 300 is worth double and 358 was an intimidating target against a fantastic Australian bowling attack. In the team discussion at the interval we reckoned that we needed to hit one boundary every over and then score the remaining 160 runs in 250 balls. It was an attempt to be positive, as there was no other option left to us at that point.

I took first strike again and managed to score a four with a mistimed pull off McGrath. When I attempted a second pull shot I got a top edge and felt utterly dejected to see McGrath settle down under the ball to take the catch. In situations like those you can only pray that the ball falls in no man's land or that the fielder makes a mistake. It was not to be and I was on my way to the pavilion. While walking back, I kept asking myself why on earth I had played that shot. Maybe I should have given myself two or three overs to settle down, but the pressure of the chase was such that attack seemed the only option.